Creative Tourism

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Introduction

Recent decades have seen a significant growth in cultural tourism, as tourists have become increasingly interested in learning about the culture, heritage and history of the destinations they visit. The emergence of cultural tourism as a major market has in turn stimulated the development of cultural and heritage attractions as a means of attracting tourists and using their expenditure to support cultural provision for local residents.

Although the cultural tourism boom has undoubtedly produced many successful policies and attractions, the very growth of cultural tourism has begun to cause problems. From an environmental point of view, the vast numbers of visitors attracted to major honeypots has begun to be a cause of concern, particularly in historic city centres. The increased commercialisation of cultural objects has also increased concerns about the commodification of local cultures.

Perhaps the greatest problem, however, is that cultural tourism has become a victim of its own success. Because cultural tourism is seen as a growth market, and cultural tourists are viewed as desirable tourists to have in the destination, there has been a massive growth in the number of cultural attractions around the world in the last 20 years. The rate of supply growth has outstripped demand growth in many cases. This has produced a situation in which cultural attractions are having to compete more intensely with each other, at the same time as the de-differentiation of the culture, leisure and tourism sectors means that they face growing competition from other types of attractions as well.

The result of this competitive struggle has become particularly clear in Europe in recent years, as major cities engage in a ‘cultural arms race’ (Richards, 2000) to build landmark cultural facilities and stage cultural mega-events to attract the cultural tourist. Development strategies have been pinned on the alliance between culture and tourism, as in the cases of Bilbao and Glasgow (Gomez, 1998). The results of such strategies are clear to see in the explosion in the number of museums in Europe. In Spain, for example, the number of museums

has doubled in the past 20 years. Whereas the first museums boom in the 19th and early 20th centuries was linked to a desire to display culture to the residents of a city or country, the latest expansion is aimed more at attracting visitors from afar. The recepticles of culture therefore also need to compete for the attention of the visitor.

In a situation in which the supply of cultural attractions is outstripping growth in demand, dilution of the market is inevitable. Across Europe average attendances per cultural attraction have been falling as growing numbers of attractions chase an almost static number of tourists. This problem is exacerbated by the fact that the larger attractions are increasing their market share at the expense of the smaller ones.

The problems associated with an increasingly saturated market and the spiraling cost of building new cultural facilities has provoked a re-assessment of the role of culture in urban regeneration.

The Creative Turn

The shift from offering culture as an object of passive consumption to developing creativity has been stimulated by the 'festivalization of the city'. Cities across the developed world have begun to develop themselves as stages for cultural performance, geared to attracting visitors who will then spend money on leisure consumption. The effect of this process is to produce very similar cultural offerings around the world. As Rasky (1998) comments:

> The Mcdonaldizaton of cultural consumption has meant that it is increasingly difficult for cities to develop a distinctive image or cultural identity on the basis of cultural consumption policies. The same cultural offerings can be found at a multiplicity of festivals all over Europe every summer. The only choice left to the cultural tourist is where to consume their culture.

The lack of distinction between cultural offerings means that cities increasingly need to rely on the 'big bang' to attraction attention and visitors. A new signature museum, an even bigger festival, even bigger stars. Bilbao, for example, has invested €150 million in the Guggenheim Museum, and London is investing €600 million in new museums in 2000. Although there are undoubted successes, and some cities have managed to generate a positive economic benefit, the escalation of cultural provision will inevitably hit the law of diminishing returns.

It is not surprising, therefore, that some cities have begun to step off the investment treadmill of cultural tourism development. In looking for new solutions to the problem of generating income and jobs and at the same time supporting cultural provision, some cities have started to adopt creative development strategies. The UK Culture Minister, Chris Smith (1998) has recently outlined the way forward for cultural policy as lying with the 'creative industries' – film, fashion, etc. Britain has flirted with selling itself as 'Cool

Britannia', a place where 'a wealth of experiences' can be offered to the consumer.

One advantage of creativity is that the creative process depends on a clustering of cultural activities and services. This tends to generate significant economic spin-off, and also leads to the regeneration of specific areas in the city. Because those involved in the creative sector tend to occupy low rent spaces, the regeneration also tends to affect run-down areas. The resulting cultural renaissance of these 'cultural quarters' in turn attracts consumers who provide a direct market for many services. Many examples of cultural quarters can be found in the UK (such as the Northern Quarter in Manchester and the Jewellery Quarter in Birmingham) and increasingly in other European cities (for example the Westergasfabriek in Amsterdam - Bonink and Hitters, 2001).

For many cities, creativity is not just an advantage – it is the only option. As the Huddersfield Creative City project points out, deindustrialising cities have only one resource: their people. Developing creativity allows the human capital of cities to be utilised to develop new solutions to the problems of economic restructuring. Even cities which do not have vast reserves of 'real cultural capital' can develop their creative capabilities to regenerate themselves.

As a result of the creative turn in urban development, some cities have begun to re-invent themselves as centres of cultural creation rather than cultural consumption.

From Cultural Tourism to Creative Tourism

The changes taking place in cultural development in general are also beginning to have an effect in the cultural tourism market. Destinations that previously relied on a fairly static offer of cultural products are now turning to the creative process as a source of product innovation.

Creative tourism has the potential to draw on local skills, expertise and traditions from many areas. For example, the creative tourist may wish to learn about:

- Arts and crafts
- Design
- Gastronomy
- Health and healing
- Languages
- Spirituality
- Nature
- Sports

All of these creatively-based products are major growth areas in tourism at the moment, and are likely to remain so in future. The major advantage of creative tourism for the destination is that it provide a new means of distinguishing its cultural products from that of its competitors. We define creative tourism as:

> Tourism which offers visitors the opportunity to develop their creative potential through active participation in courses and learning experiences which are characteristic of the holiday destination where they are undertaken.

There are a number of reasons why creative tourism can improve on cultural tourism (Richards, 2001):

1) Creativity can potentially create value more easily because of its scarcity. Creativity is an attribute supposedly possessed by relatively few people, whereas thanks to the broadening concept of 'culture', cultural products are ubiquitous. In the cultural tourism market cultural attractions of themselves no longer function as a means of distinction – every city has museums and monuments. The multiplication of cultural cities in Europe has meant that a new source of distinction had to be found in the 'creative city' (Landry and Bianchini, 1995).

2) Creativity allows destinations to innovate new products relatively rapidly, giving them a competitive advantage over other locations.

3) Creativity is a process, and creative resources are therefore more sustainable. Whereas physical cultural resources, such as museums and monuments, may wear out over time and become degraded, creative resources are arguably infinitely renewable. This rapid growth of cultural and arts festivals in Europe in recent years underlines this fact.

4) Creativity is mobile. Where cultural consumption is dependent on a concentration of cultural resources, creativity can become extremely mobile – arts performances and artworks can today be produced virtually anywhere, without the need for dedicated infrastructure.

These advantages should ensure that creative modes of tourism become more popular with tourism destinations in future. However, it is also important to ensure that the new creative tourism products match the needs of consumers.

Demand for Creative Tourism

Creativity is increasingly recognised as essential for success in many aspects of life: personal development, life-long learning, management, even politics. As leisure time in the developed world becomes more scarce, holidays can provide important opportunities for people to develop their creative capacities. This opportunity has already been seized upon by Disney, who are offering a wide range of creative and self-development courses at the Disney Institute in Florida.

Tourists stand to benefit from stretching their capabilities and learning new skills, possibilities which work pressures in the home environment often leave little time for. People increasingly feel a need to distinguish themselves in an

homogenized world and are becoming more curious about the creative process. A growing number of people are seeking creative outlets for their talents, and want to learn while they are on holiday. Recent surveys by ATLAS in different European countries has shown that over two thirds of visitors to cultural attractions are motivated by a desire to learn new things. Over a third of visitors to rural environments indicate an interest in learning crafts skills, and this proportion is almost twice as high among visitors classifying themselves as 'cultural tourists' (Richards, 1999).

This desire for learning and self-development is related to trends towards 'skilled consumption' (Richards, 1996) and the search for individual identity and meaning in the face of cultural homogenization (Ritzer, 1999). This leads to a situation where passive leisure pursuits begin to be replaced (or at least supplemented) by 'serious leisure' activities and 'recreation leisure' is replaced by 'creative leisure' (Dumazedier, 1967).

So much for the theory, what about the practice?

Of course, the idea that creativity will become more important has been with us for a long time, as Dumazedier's work shows. So far, the predictions of the arrival of the leisure society, in which creativity would be paramount, have been premature (Richards, 2000). However, the fact that the logic of leisure and tourism production is now tending towards a greater need for creativity suggests that the convergence of demand for and the supply of creativity may mean that creative tourism actually does emerge as an important market soon.

In order to ascertain if this is so, more research is of course needed. One of the proposals currently being examined by the ATLAS Cultural Tourism Research Group is to increase the focus of the research on the role of creativity, and in particular to look at the role of the European Cultural Capital event in stimulating creative tourism. This will form part of the next survey period, which is planned for 2001. However, the authors would also welcome any other thoughts that ATLAS members may have on the issue.

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